

COLOURS OF BOUNTY
A pulses processing plant at the Bawana Industrial Area in Delhi

THE CHANGE-MAKERS

NATIONAL AGRICULTURAL COOPERATIVE MARKETING FEDERATION OF INDIA (NAFED)

- Established in 1958, NAFED procures, stores and distributes 16 notified commodities, including pulses such as chana, tur, moong, soyabean and lentils
- The public agency has been at the centre of creating stable growth in cultivation and farmer remuneration

INDIAN COUNCIL OF AGRICULTURAL RESEARCH (ICAR)

- Thanks to the premium research institution, more than 300 high-yielding varieties of pulses were notified for commercial production in the past decade

nological breakthroughs in pulses cultivation. It hasn't helped that India's stand on the controversial genetically modified (GM) crops for edible produce remains unresolved. The National Food Security Mission-Pulses was formulated to focus on cultivating quality seeds, disseminating agricultural technologies, and promoting best practices. Over the past five years, India has also buoyed up the MSP for pulses. However, challenges persist as government agencies procure limited stocks for price stability, thus failing to offer an attractive cushion to farmers so as to incentivise them towards crop diversification.

WHAT INDIA NEEDS TO MASTER

The path forward entails more than high-yield variants. India requires a consistent policy framework to instil farmer confidence in ramping up pulse cultivation. The past six years have witnessed several policy shifts, driven in part by the back-to-back drought seasons in 2015-16, which led to soaring prices. Experts like former agriculture secretary Siraj Hussain have suggested that diverting land from rice cultivation may be necessary to achieve a targeted production hike of 5 MT over the next seven years. However, for this to materialise, a robust policy is imperative, guaranteeing profitable price signals for pulse crops, especially in irrigated areas.

Pulses cultivation is inherently sensitive to weather conditions, making consistent government procurement essential. However, farmers lament the limited procurement of pulses at MSP by state agencies and the sporadic trading policies, which deter newcomers. To counter this, the government enhanced the allocation under the Price Support Scheme and set up a Price Stabilisation Fund for pulses procurement. While procurement reached an all-time high of 4.2 million tonnes in 2018-19, it dipped to 1.2 million tonnes in 2021-22. Again, for 2023-24, allocation for both the schemes has been cut drastically.

A holistic approach encompassing policy stability, incentives and technological advancements is crucial in ensuring sustained growth in pulses production, which can help meet India's food security and self-sufficiency goals. ■



"There is a need for comprehensive pulses policies to develop the entire chain—from seed, cultivation, harvest, market linkage to processing and marketing of the final product"

– DIPAK GOYAL
President, Bawana Food Processors Association, Delhi